

1890–1959, CZECH

Prolific Czech composer Martinů was born to poor parents in a rural town in Bohemia. Impressed by his violin-playing, townspeople paid for him to attend the Prague Conservatory. His first success as a composer came with a cantata celebrating Czechoslovakia's independence, premiered in 1919. He played as an orchestral violinist and in 1923 moved to Paris, where he was influenced by the current fashions for jazz and Neo-Classicism. He survived poverty with the aid of a seamstress, Charlotte Quennehen, whom he married in 1931. He established a growing reputation with his ballets, operas, orchestral pieces, and concertos before the Nazi occupation of France in 1940 drove him to flee to the US. Living there until 1953, he produced numerous works, including six symphonies, a violin concerto, and an opera commissioned for television. He returned to Europe for his final years, dying in Switzerland.

KEY WORKS: *La Revue de cuisine* (ballet), 1927; *Double Concerto for Two String Orchestras, Piano and Timpani*, 1938; *Symphony No. 1*, 1942; *The Greek Passion* (opera), 1957.